

My project was initially inspired by the last paragraph of the conclusion of *Any Means Necessary*. “My experience of race is very different Rather than letting language speak for itself (human or computer), Bertram speaks past the filter of those generators to share their lived, individual, and sometimes traumatic experiences of race and identity in 21st century America.” (Zach Whalen, 2023). Although the author, Zach Whalen, said he mentioned it at the beginning, what truly sparked my thinking was the combination at the end. The first part discusses how Whalen, as a beneficiary of "mass racism," experiences "race" differently from others. This reminded me of the concept of "perspective-taking" I was taught as a child. That is, what would you do if you were in that situation? Would you make the same decision, and thus determine whether others' choices were correct or just? Then, perhaps I'm being too pedantic, but when I think about "Rather than letting language speak for itself (human or computer)," it also contains a feeling similar to "shutting the machine up." While perhaps code and machines have no emotions, I prefer that we "teach" machines and code how to speak, rather than "force" them to speak how we want them to.

Thus, I conceived the initial idea for this project. When we use code to instruct the machine's output, can we think in reverse, or use the "perspective-taking" I mentioned, to let ourselves have the machine's thoughts and output? Initially, I envisioned the "user" as an AI, incapable of understanding emotions, requiring us to generate specific content. However, given the current complexity and richness of AI output—including drawings, music, and even videos—limiting it to text was inappropriate. Therefore, I simplified it, allowing the "virtual" machine to communicate with "humans" through "code," with humans outputting thoughts or "vocabularies" that don't exist in the machine's binary code. At the same time, I don't want "humans" unrestricted output; frequently erroneous language was ultimately "optimized" or

removed. So, I added a "human-readable" rule, similar to the near-unlimited natural language readability of many modern machine languages. This rule grants the machine much "machine-readable" content—not entirely unreadable to humans, but still quite challenging.

This feeling of machine-human communication reminded me of many late 20th-century DOS text adventure games, like Inrac Corporation's *Racter*. I've played a couple more, but since English isn't my native language, I haven't explored them in depth. Therefore, I designed the overall art style of the project to resemble DOS. Some works nowadays, categorized as analog horror, including but not limited to photos, videos, and games, bear a resemblance to DOS, a last-century operating system. Analog horror often combines Rule Horror elements into games, such as "*Escape the Backrooms*" and "*That's Not My Neighbor*," which are linked to unusual rules. There's also "*Papers, Please*," but it lacks a true "horror" element. My idea already incorporates "rules," and given modern fears about machines potentially possessing self-awareness, I added randomly occurring "bugs." Incorrect responses to these bugs will have consequences.

Initially, I planned to let the program automatically generate random combinations of letters and numbers of characters for the text selection. However, in my previous project, I had the program export some "meaningless" phrases, so I didn't intend to do that. I play many live-service games made by Chinese companies. One game called *Zenless Zone Zero*, in a version update in August 2025, had its Chinese title "Do Not Go Gentle into That Good Night," the same as the nineteen-line poem (or Villanelle) of the same name by Welsh poet Dylan Thomas. I realized that many games have similarly poetic mission titles, strongly related to the game or code. So I selected four games I'd played: *Honkai: Star Rail* (2023), *Zenless Zone Zero* (2024), *Arknights* (2019), and *Girls' Frontline* (2016), and compiled a total of 45 different

mission titles. These four games have vastly different backstories, so cutting and pasting these mission titles from one game to another is a kind of cut-up, though I did it unconsciously.

The final project involves a program or website generating a piece of code, and the human user inputs a phrase. Simultaneously, some buggy code I designed appears randomly, requiring the user to identify it. Ultimately, the user might receive a poem composed of many game titles, designed by the "code," entered by themselves, but not truly their own.